long distance and most other public transport was owned and operated by the government.

Railways Remains a Government Undertaking

The railway network in India was initially built by the British, beginning with the first 34 km railway line between Bombay (Bori Bunder) and Thane, which opened for passenger transport in 1853. A number of privately owned railway companies were set up between 1855 and 1880 to build railway lines and establish rail transport in different parts of the country. The railway network in India had reached 9000 km by 1880. The British government started purchasing private railway companies in the beginning of the twentieth century; it is reported that by 1907, the entire major railway network was purchased and owned by the British India government. The Railway Board was established in 1901 and railway finances were separated from general finances in 1924.

By 1930, the Indian railway network had become one of the largest in the world with an overall length of 66,000 km carrying about 620 million passengers and 90 million tonnes of goods annually. Partition in 1947 divided this network. In 1950, India’s railway network was 53,596 km long, which rose to 64,600 km by 2012 and exceeded 67,500 km in 2020. Many railway lines have been converted to double tracks after Independence. Total railway tracks (counting double lines as two tracks) exceed 96,000 km now.

The Railways continued to operate as a department of the Government of India with the Railway Board interposed as a kind of corporate structure and government secretariat to manage the system. The Railway Budget retained a separate identity until September 2016 when it was merged with the General Budget.